

Through her diligence, she was able to preserve the family wealth as a trustee on behalf of her young son. At age 18, Prince Albert inherited the family fortune, which had endured thanks to the efforts of his mother.

THE PUBLIC SPECTACLE

A bad marriage is another way to lose a fortune. That's why the heirs of the Spanish House of Alba forced their mother to take legal precautions before her recent marriage to a much younger man.

Spain's 85-year-old Duchess of Alba has more royal titles than anyone else in the world—40 of them. Her full name is Maria del Rosario Cayetana Alfonsa Victoria Eugenia Francisca Fitz-James Stuart y de Silva. She's distantly related to Queen Elizabeth and Winston Churchill.

She's known for her flamboyant style and frizzy hair and for having received extensive plastic surgery.

Her wealth is estimated in the range of \$800 million to \$5 billion. She owns estates all around Spain. The 500-year-old House of Alba owns paintings by Goya and Velazquez, a first-edition copy of Cervantes's *Don Quixote* and letters written by Christopher Columbus. Much of this is classified as part of Spain's national heritage and cannot be sold without government permission.

In August 2011, she married Alfonso Diez, a 60-year-old civil servant from Madrid earning \$2,000 per month. He had to sign away his claim to the wealth of the House of Alba and any title. But he's planning to quit his job and live the lifestyle of a duke.¹⁰

The duchess's six children balked at the idea of their mother marrying this man. So the month before the wedding, the duchess signed over vast chunks of her estate to them and her grandchildren, to essentially buy their support of her marriage.

She was quoted in the Spanish press saying, "I have been alone in this project, and got nothing but negative opinions until they realized what kind of man he is."

The wedding itself was a spectacle. A crowd of several hundred clapped and cheered as the duchess kicked off her shoes and danced the flamenco